PRACTICAL PLAYBOOK · BUILT FROM X'S OPEN-SOURCE ALGORITHM · 2026

How to actually grow on X

No theory. Seven moves, real examples you can copy, and a way to tell if they're working. If you only keep one page, keep this one.

The algorithm doesn't reward your best post. It rewards the account that consistently makes the right people reply, save, and stay — and it judges your whole account, not each tweet.

So stop chasing the one viral banger. Build an account the algorithm can trust and place. Everything below is how.

DO MORE

- Be obviously about **one thing**
- Write posts people **have to reply to** — then reply back fast
- Reply to every comment in hour 1
- Native media that earns the tap
- Posts worth **saving / DMing**

STOP DOING

- Chasing likes / "bangers"
- Obsessing over "best time to post"
- Rage-bait that escapes your niche
- Hashtag stuffing; links in the post
- Posting 6 unrelated topics

IGNORE (DEAD)

- "Best time" charts
- "Post decays after 6 hours"
- "10 replies in 5 min = viral"
- Hashtag reach hacks
- The "TweepCred 65" number

Built from the code X open-sourced (github.com/xai-org/x-algorithm) + the 2023 weights. Where the code is silent, this says so. Not affiliated with X.

BEFORE THE MOVES · THE ONE FACT THAT REORDERS EVERYTHING

What each action is actually worth

X scores a post by predicting what you'll *do* with it, and the values are wildly lopsided. Read this once and half your habits change.

A reply you reply back to (you answer their comment)	**≈ 150 likes**
A reply to your post	**≈ 27 likes**
Someone opens your profile, then engages	**≈ 24 likes**
Someone reads / dwells 2+ minutes	**≈ 22 likes**
A repost	**≈ 2 likes**
A like	**1 like**
A mute / block / "show less"	**≈ −148 likes**
A report	**buries it**

Numbers are X's published 2023 weights — today's exact values are private, but the *order* still holds. Bookmarks aren't in the public list but behave like a strong positive.

> **Translation: a post that gets 12 real replies you answer beats a post that gets 1,000 silent likes. And one block from the wrong person wipes out ~148 likes of work. Conversation > applause. Always.**

This is why the moves on the next pages all point the same way: manufacture replies, answer them, keep the wrong crowd from blocking you, and look trustworthy enough that the algorithm bothers to show your stuff at all.

Move 1–2

1 Be obviously about one thing

Why, plainly: X shows your posts to people who already engage with your topic. If your account is a blur of crypto, fitness, and hot takes, it can't tell who to show you to — so it shows you to no one new.

The test: if a stranger reads your last 10 posts, can they finish "this account is about ___" in one word? If not, that's your #1 problem.

@you · profile that gets recommended — PLACEABLE

Last 10 posts: prediction-market liquidity, why Polymarket odds drift, a teardown of a bad market, a build update on your PM tool. → X knows exactly who to show you to.

DO

- One clear lane per account
- Even your replies stay on-topic

DON'T

- Chase an off-topic viral hit
- Run 4 unrelated themes

Working? A stranger can name your topic in one word from your last 10 posts.

2 Write posts people have to reply to — then reply back

Why, plainly: a reply you answer is the single most valuable thing that can happen to a post (≈150 likes). So engineer the reply, then collect it.

@you — WEAK

"Prediction markets are the future."

Gets a few likes. No reason to reply. Dies.

@you — STRONG

"Most prediction markets die from thin liquidity, not bad odds. The fix everyone skips: subsidise the market maker, not the trader. What am I missing here?"

Takes a stance + invites correction → informed people reply → you answer each one.

DO

- End with a real question or a claim worth countering
- Answer every reply in the first hour

DON'T

- Fake "thoughts?" bait with nothing to react to
- Post and disappear

Working? Replies per 1,000 impressions going up; you answered 80%+ within an hour.

Move 3–5

3 Be in your replies for the first 60 minutes

Why, plainly: there's no "best time to post" — your post doesn't compete with others for a slot. Timing only matters because you need to be awake to reply back while comments roll in.

So don't post at a "peak time" and walk away. Post when you've got a free hour to sit in the comments. Your reply to their reply is worth more than the whole post's likes.

DO

- Post → then block 60 min to reply
- Treat the comment section as part of the post

DON'T

- Auto-schedule for a "best time" while you're asleep

Working? % of posts where you replied within 60 min is near 100%.

4 Use media that earns the tap

Why, plainly: "expand photo" and "watch video" are things X scores — text-only posts can't earn them. But only real media counts; decoration earns nothing.

earns it — GOOD

A screenshot of the actual liquidity chart, or a 40-sec face-to-camera explaining the trade.

decoration — CUT IT

A generic stock image, or a 3-sec meme clip stapled on to "use video."

Working? Your media posts get expands/watches above your text-only baseline.

5 Make posts worth saving and DMing

Why, plainly: a post sent in a DM or saved is a high-intent signal X tracks separately from a like. Dwell (time spent reading) counts twice.

The test before you post: *would someone screenshot this and send it to one specific friend with "this is us"?*

@you — SAVE-WORTHY

"7 ways prediction markets quietly lie to you (and how to read around each). ↓" → a thread people bookmark and send.

DO

- Threads that fully teach one thing
- Lists / frameworks people store

DON'T

- Pad length with fluff (people bounce = bad signal)

Working? Bookmarks + shares per post trending up.

Move 6–7

6 Look like a trusted human (this gate is invisible)

Why, plainly: X has an account-trust score. If it reads you as low-trust or botty, your posts barely get distributed — no hook fixes that. Trust flows in from credible accounts that engage you.

- ☐ **Following ≤ followers** (or close) — a 4,000/200 ratio screams desperation
- ☐ **Premium on**, account **3+ months old**, no follow/unfollow games
- ☐ **Reply to 5 credible accounts in your niche, daily** — their trust rubs off on you

Working? Ratio healthy; credible niche accounts start replying to and following you.

7 Don’t let the wrong room block you

Why, plainly: one block ≈ minus 148 likes, and it generalises — it teaches X to show you less everywhere. Rage-bait that escapes your niche is a trap: big numbers, real damage.

If a post is “doing numbers” but from people who’ll never follow you and some are muting/blocking, it’s *hurting* the account. Reach from the wrong room is negative reach.

DO

- Match the message to your actual audience
- Drop formats that pull mutes from outsiders

DON’T

- Bait outrage for impressions

Working? Mutes / blocks / “not interested” per post stay near zero.

The order matters: 1 & 6 first (be placeable + trusted), then 2, 3, 5 (manufacture conversation), then polish with 4, and never trip 7. A great hook on an untrusted, blurry account still dies.

STEAL THESE · POST SHAPES THAT FIRE THE RIGHT SIGNALS

Copy-paste templates

Each shape is built to pull replies, saves, or dwell. Swap in your topic. The green bits are the fill-ins.

01 · THE CORRECTION MAGNET

“Everyone says `[common belief]`. It’s actually `[your contrarian take]` — because `[one reason]`. Tell me where I’m wrong.”

02 · THE TEARDOWN (SAVES + DWELL)

“I went through `[thing]` so you don’t have to. `[N]` things that surprised me: 1) … 2) … 3) …”

03 · THE BUILD-IN-PUBLIC UPDATE

“Day `[N]` building `[project]`. Today: `[specific win or fail + a real number]`. Next: `[what’s scary]`.”

04 · THE GENUINE ASK (PURE REPLY BAIT, THE GOOD KIND)

“If you’ve actually `[done the hard thing]` — how did you handle `[specific problem]`? Mine is `[your situation]`.”

05 · THE ONE-LINER WITH A THREAD UNDER IT

“`[Sharp, debatable claim in one line]`.” → first reply: “Here’s the case ↓” (keeps links/depth out of the main post)

06 · THE LIST PEOPLE BOOKMARK

“`[N]` `[tools / mistakes / lessons]` for `[your niche]` nobody tells you: …”

Rule that overrides all six: put external links in the *first reply*, not the post — link-in-post reach is penalised. And be there to answer (Move 3).

WHEN IT'S NOT WORKING

Posts dying? Run this checklist

- ☐ Could a stranger name your topic in one word from your last 10 posts? `no → Move 1`
- ☐ Did your last 5 posts actually invite a reply? `no → Move 2`
- ☐ Were you in the replies within an hour? `no → Move 3`
- ☐ Is your media earning taps, or just decoration? `decoration → Move 4`
- ☐ Following way more than follow you / new account / botty patterns? `yes → Move 6`
- ☐ Any post pulling blocks/mutes from outside your niche? `yes → Move 7`
- ☐ Strong post *still* dead? It may be filtered for safety/spam — different problem, not your hook.

Stop believing these

"Post at the best time"	No slot-race exists. Be present to reply, post whenever.
"Posts decay after 6 hours"	That rule was removed. A good post can move days later.
"10 replies in 5 min makes you go viral"	Velocity tricks were removed in 2026.
"Hashtags expand reach"	Ignored at best, spammy at worst.
"Threads get a completion bonus"	No such bonus in the code. Threads help only via dwell.
"Below 65 TweepCred only 3 posts show"	Not in the code — a blog myth. Trust matters; the number is made up.

Sources: github.com/xai-org/x-algorithm (Apache-2.0, public) · phoenix/README.md · twitter/the-algorithm (2023 weights & TweepCred). The exact 2026 weights are private; this playbook uses the public 2023 numbers for order, and flags anything that's a guess. Not affiliated with X or xAI.